# Personal Worldview Essay

After reading and thinking about worldviews and how they affect how we act and think about ourselves and each other, consider your own worldviews and what has shaped them. Write an essay that explains your worldviews and how you think they were formed.

This is a personal essay that will require some serious self-reflection and critical thinking. Examining your own worldview and its context is not an easy exercise and requires a lot of deep thinking, much of which may be uncomfortable. Be prepared for this and be willing to challenge yourself.

## Basics

- The essay should be at least 1200 words with fully-developed ideas and details.
- You **must** answer all questions asked in each section below.
- You do not have to use sources for the essay, but you should use your readings and the videos you watched to inform your ideas.

## Body

*Introduction*

Write an introduction that describes your personal, social, and cultural identities. Make sure that you include all three of these parts of your identity, including one or two examples of each (more is fine). This introduction should be at least 200 words long.

*Body Paragraphs*

**Your worldview**

Summarize your worldview. Be honest. Examine your beliefs without judgment. Include all four of the following categories. This section should be approximately 400 words (more is fine)

- How do you acquire most of your knowledge (epistemology)?
- What are some examples of things you believe are true or not true (ontology)?
- What do you believe is important/trivial, good/bad, fair/unfair? What do you hope for, for yourself or for the world (axiology)?
- How do you see yourself in relation to the world or to other people (cosmology)? This might include your religious faith or lack of religion, but it could also relate to your general idea of yourself as connected or not connected to other people. Are you more of an individualist (you believe your success depends on yourself, or you do things primarily for your benefit) or more of a collectivist (you believe your success is connected to others, or you concentrate on how your actions benefit others)?

**The origins of your worldviews**

Where did you acquire your worldviews? Our beliefs often owe nothing to logic, but we believe what we believe for a reason, based on how we've taught how to live our lives. Again, be honest, and examine these experiences and relationships without judgment. This section should be approximately 400 words (more is fine).

- What relationships in your life have formed your belief system? These could include family, friends, or other significant individuals--your social identities. Think about what these people have said or the way they have treated you.
- What experiences in your life led you to believe what you believe? These could include significant events in your life, or just events that have happened to you consistently. Think about how your personal identities were formed.
- What structures from the world around you have influenced your belief system? These could include your cultural, ethnic, language, national, or religious background, or other parts of you that you were born with or were decided for you--things that have formed your cultural identities.

*Conclusion*

Close your essay by explaining which parts of your experience or identities have the **most significant** impact on your worldview. Explain **why** you believe these things are the most important or significant. This section should be at least 200 words.

## Essay Memo

*Attached to the end of your essay in the same document*, type an essay memo of at least 100 words (more is good) that answers the following questions:

- Who else saw your essay during your writing process? (writing center consultants, friends, family members?)
- How long did your writing process take from beginning to end?
- What are the strengths and weaknesses of your essay?
- What were your triumphs (things you enjoyed or did well with) and struggles during your writing process?
- What grade would *you* give your essay, and why?